



BEFORE

Civil War commanders adopted infantry tactics based on a European tradition that had proved effective since the introduction of the flintlock musket around 1700.

FIGHTING DRILL



THE WAR WITH MEXICO

European infantry were taught to fight as **rigidly drilled automatons**. When on the defensive, they **stood in the open**, firing disciplined volleys with their muskets. For the offense, they **advanced steadily across open ground in tight formation** of column or line with bayonets fixed. To **defend themselves against charging cavalry, the infantry formed squares**.

These basic infantry tactics, which had been used in the Napoleonic Wars, were studied as models at American military colleges and were employed by American infantry in the **War with Mexico** in 1846–48.

Later European conflicts, such as the Crimean War of 1854–56, showed that **better weaponry made traditional frontal infantry assaults very costly**, especially when defenders were entrenched in field fortifications. These lessons were largely ignored in the United States and had to be learned over again in the Civil War.

Infantry began the Civil War equipped with an assortment of weapons, including inaccurate, old-fashioned smoothbore flintlock muskets. By the second year of the war, however, the standard weapon on both sides had become the rifle musket—either an Enfield or a Springfield. The rapid loading and firing of this weapon